# MENNA CAPELIN BISHOP

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## EDUCATION

**PhD in Economics** — Sep 2023 – Sep 2027 (expected)
*University of Warwick* — *Coventry, UK*
Primary field: Development Economics
Secondary fields: Labour Economics, Environmental Economics

**MRes in Economics** (Distinction) — Sep 2021 – Sep 2023
*University of Warwick* — *Coventry, UK*

**BSc Social Policy and Economics** (First Class) — Sep 2016 – Sep 2019
*London School of Economics and Political Science* — *London, UK*

## WORKING PAPERS

"Paying to Be Paid Early: Debt Bondage in India's Brick Kilns" **(Job Market Paper)**.

"Blossoming Towns", with Niclas Moneke and Céline Zipfel.

## WORK IN PROGRESS

"Jobs to End Poverty: Evidence from Bangladesh", with Oriana Bandiera, Robin Burgess, Stefano Caria, Munshi Sulaiman and Jack Thiemel (working paper in preparation).

## PUBLICATIONS

Fetzer, T., Gazzè, L. and Bishop, M. C. (2024). "Distributional and Climate Implications of Policy Responses to Energy Price Shocks". *Economic Policy*, 39(120), 711–756.

Bishop, M. C., Burgess, R. and Zipfel, C. (2023). "Technology and Development". In Madon, T., Gadgil, A. J., Anderson, R., Casaburi, L., Lee, K., Rezaee, A. (eds), *Introduction to Development Engineering*. Springer, Cham.

## CONFERENCE AND SEMINAR PRESENTATIONS

*"Paying to Be Paid Early: Debt Bondage in India's Brick Kilns"*

Econometric Society European Winter Meeting* 2026
Northeastern Universities Development Consortium (NEUDC), Cornell University* 2026
Nordic Conference in Development Economics, Växjö 2026
QMUL Economics and Finance Workshop for PhD and Post-doctoral Students, London 2026
Doctorissimes, Université Paris 1 Panthéon-Sorbonne 2026

*"Blossoming Towns"*

EBRD and CEPR Research Symposium on Demographic Change, London 2025
Women's Employment and Empowerment in Low-Income Countries, Royal Holloway 2025
Gender-Responsive Social Protection and Employment Policies, IDOS, Bonn 2024

*"Distributional and Climate Implications of Policy Responses to Energy Price Shocks"*

LSE Environment Day, London 2023

*Scheduled

## RESEARCH EXPERIENCE AND AFFILIATIONS

**Affiliated Scholar** Mar 2024 – present
*Data, Policy and Innovation Centre (DPIC)* *Odisha, India*
A partnership between the Government of Odisha and the University of Chicago Trust.

**Research Assistant to Professors Oriana Bandiera and Robin Burgess** 2019 – 2021
*London School of Economics and Political Science* *London, UK*

## TEACHING

**Graduate Teaching Assistant**

Topics in Development Economics (EC310), *University of Warwick* 2025–26
Microeconomic Principles I (EC201), *London School of Economics* 2020–21
Economics B (EC102), *London School of Economics* 2019–20

## GRANTS

G2LM|LIC/STEG, "Women's Work in Markets of the 21st Century", £25,000, Co-PI 2025
STEG Small Research Grant, £15,000, Sole PI 2024
ESRC Overseas Fieldwork Grant, Midlands Graduate School DTP, £4,672 2024

## AWARDS AND SCHOLARSHIPS

ESRC Midlands Graduate School DTP Scholarship, 3.5-year award 2023–2027
Janet Beveridge Award for Outstanding Achievement, London School of Economics 2019

## RESEARCH SKILLS AND LANGUAGES

**Software** R (including GIS), Stata, LaTeX
**Survey tools** SurveyCTO, KoboToolbox
**Languages** English (native), French (fluent)

## REFERENCES

**Professor Anant Sudarshan**
*Department of Economics*
*University of Warwick*
anant.sudarshan@warwick.ac.uk

**Professor Stefano Caria**
*Department of Economics*
*University of Oxford*
stefano.caria@economics.ox.ac.uk

**Professor Sharun Mukand**
*Department of Economics*
*University of Warwick*
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## ABSTRACTS

*"Paying to Be Paid Early: Debt Bondage in India's Brick Kilns"* **(Job Market Paper)**

Bonded workers take credit from their employer, voluntarily forgoing the freedom to leave until this is repaid. This paper asks why, using India's brick kilns as a setting. Kilns recruit their 15 million migrant workers with advance payments, later deducted from earnings. Larger advances carry implicit interest: workers taking them are paid less per brick. Partnering with employers, I advertise real vacancies with randomised terms to 1,494 Odisha households. Applicants favour high advance contracts by 10 percentage points, implicitly borrowing at over 700% annually. Demand concentrates amongst credit constrained workers and rises after negative income shocks, as a rational borrower's would. However, workers fail the required arithmetic, and three quarters wrongly believe high advance contracts pay more. Returning a year later, I make the interest explicit in an information intervention. It does not shift beliefs or reduce demand. Errors that resist information may strengthen the case for regulating advances, though this would remove the poorest households' only source of credit.

*"Blossoming Towns"*, with Niclas Moneke and Céline Zipfel

Towns and cities create jobs and income. Can the arrival of new jobs also create a town? We study large agro-industrial labour demand shocks in rural sub-Saharan Africa: flower farms in Kenya. Rising production costs in Europe generate a boom in Kenyan cut-flower export production, providing stable wage jobs for mostly low-skilled women. We exploit the specific requirements of cut-flower production to track the arrival and growth of greenhouses over the last two decades. We find large increases in wage employment and home-to-market transformation within agriculture, especially for women. Urbanisation unfolds: population growth and in-migration are flanked by an emerging private rental market for housing. Housing quality and infrastructure access improve, wealth accumulates. Educational investments increase while fertility decreases. Suggestive evidence highlights that the resulting towns initiate occupational change, motivate forward-looking investment and even survive flower farm closures – indicating towns that can sustain themselves as centres of economic activity.

*"Jobs to End Poverty: Evidence from Bangladesh"*, with Oriana Bandiera, Robin Burgess, Stefano Caria, Munshi Sulaiman and Jack Thiemel

Do the poor have high returns from trainable human capital? Can they afford to pay for it? And are they differentially targeted by the organizations that offer training? We provide unique evidence on these questions by combining a household census (N=42,895) in urban Bangladesh, a randomized controlled trial of an on-the-job training intervention, unique data on the targeting of the implementing partner, and a structural model. We find that take-up of the training at full price is minimal, and there are no effects on labor market outcomes. The poor, however, increase employment and consumption under a 70% discount. We also document that, for the same program, the implementing NGO would have selected richer beneficiaries who are more likely to enroll in training. Our structural model rationalizes these findings by estimating that the poor have higher-than-average returns to training, but they also experience higher participation costs, and are hence targeted less frequently by an implementer that wants to maximise take-up. We confirm the central finding that the poor have higher-than-average returns to training in a re-analysis of previous training experiments, using machine learning predictions of outcomes and treatment effects.